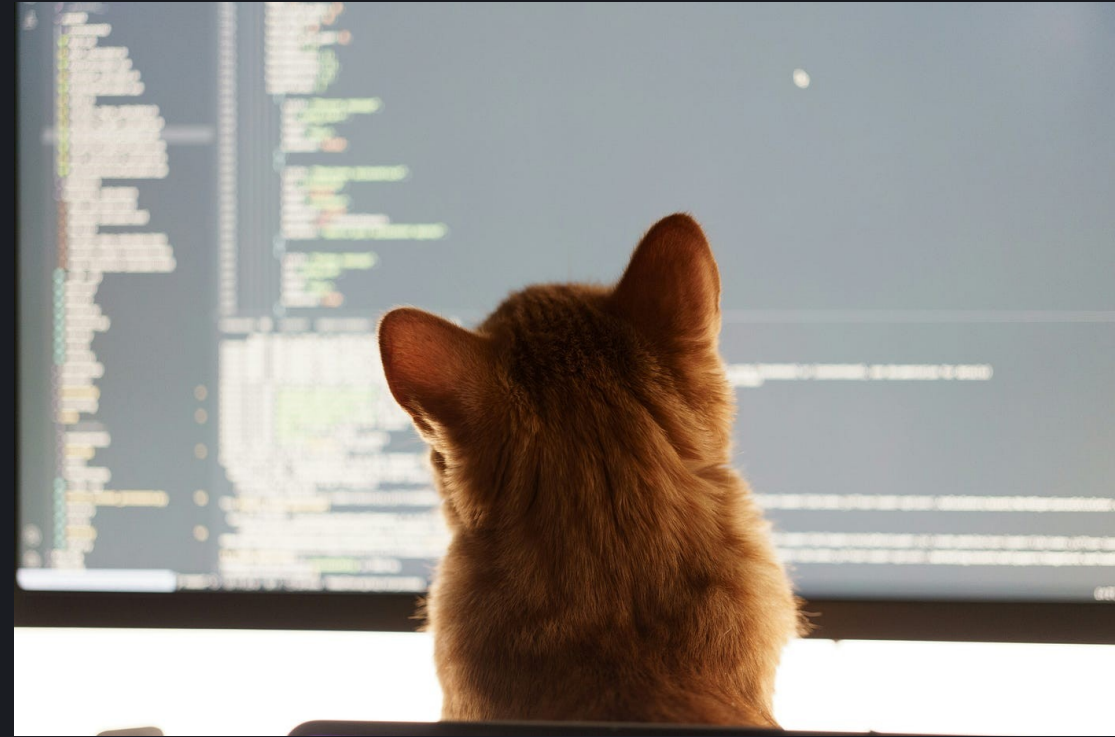


N8N TUTORIAL

Build Your First No-Code
Automation Workflow,
Step by Step



Based on the article by Rizwanhoda for Towards AI

What Is n8n?

- › A visual, no-code workflow automation platform (pronounced 'n-eight-n')
- › Connect apps and services by linking nodes on a canvas, no code required
- › Free and open-source when you self-host it on your own machine

Why It Matters for Beginners

- › No coding background needed: drag, drop, and connect nodes
- › Scales from a two-step automation to a full backend workflow
- › Tasks that used to take hours by hand now run in one click

Installing n8n: Two Paths

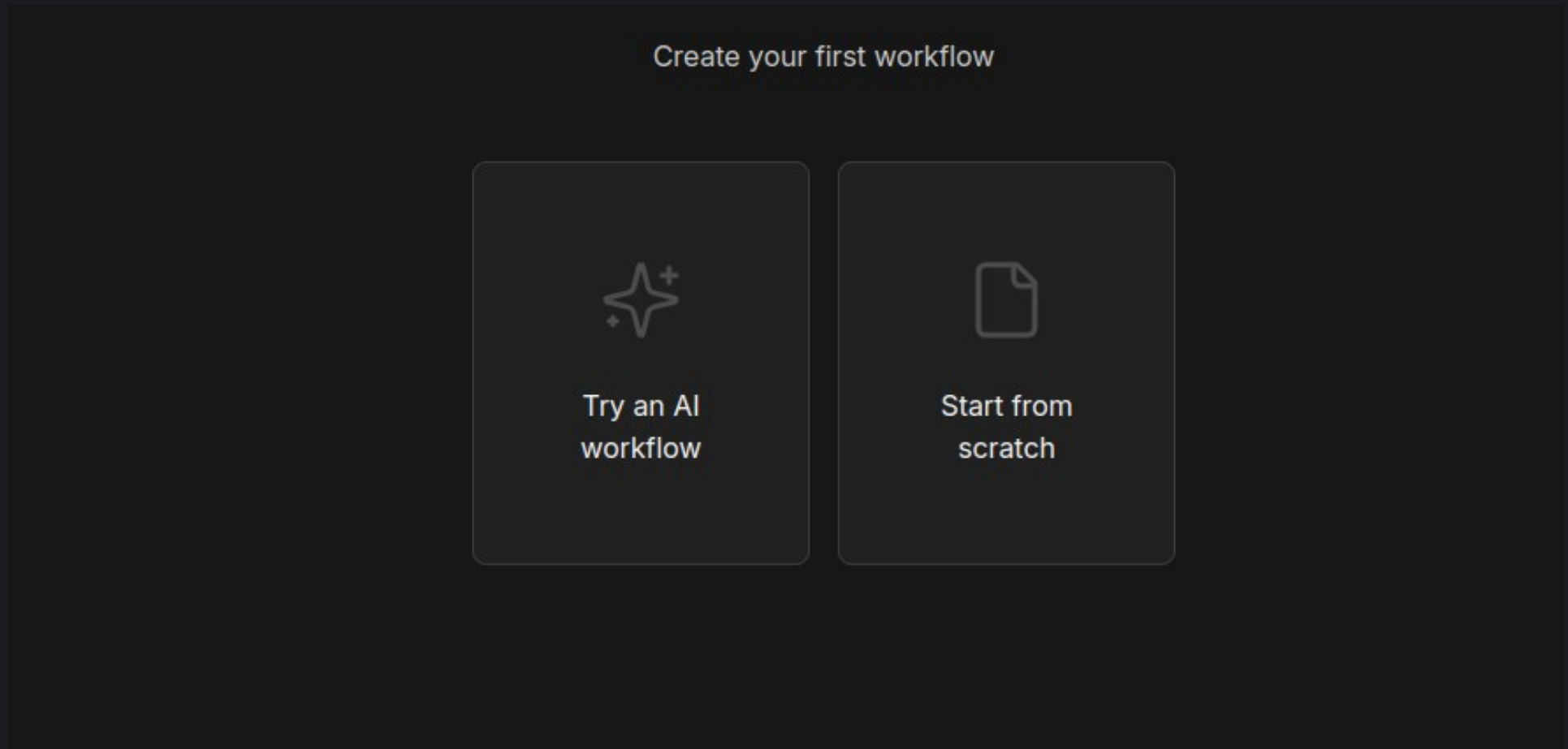
- > Local (self-hosted): needs Node.js first, then full control and privacy
- > n8n Cloud: sign up and start building in minutes, zero setup
- > This tutorial uses the cloud version for every screenshot ahead

```
$ npm install -g n8n
$ n8n start
# then open http://localhost:5678

$ npm update -g n8n    # to upgrade later
```

The Cloud Editor

After signing up and answering a few setup questions, click “Start Automating”. You land on a blank canvas with one node already placed, ready to build.



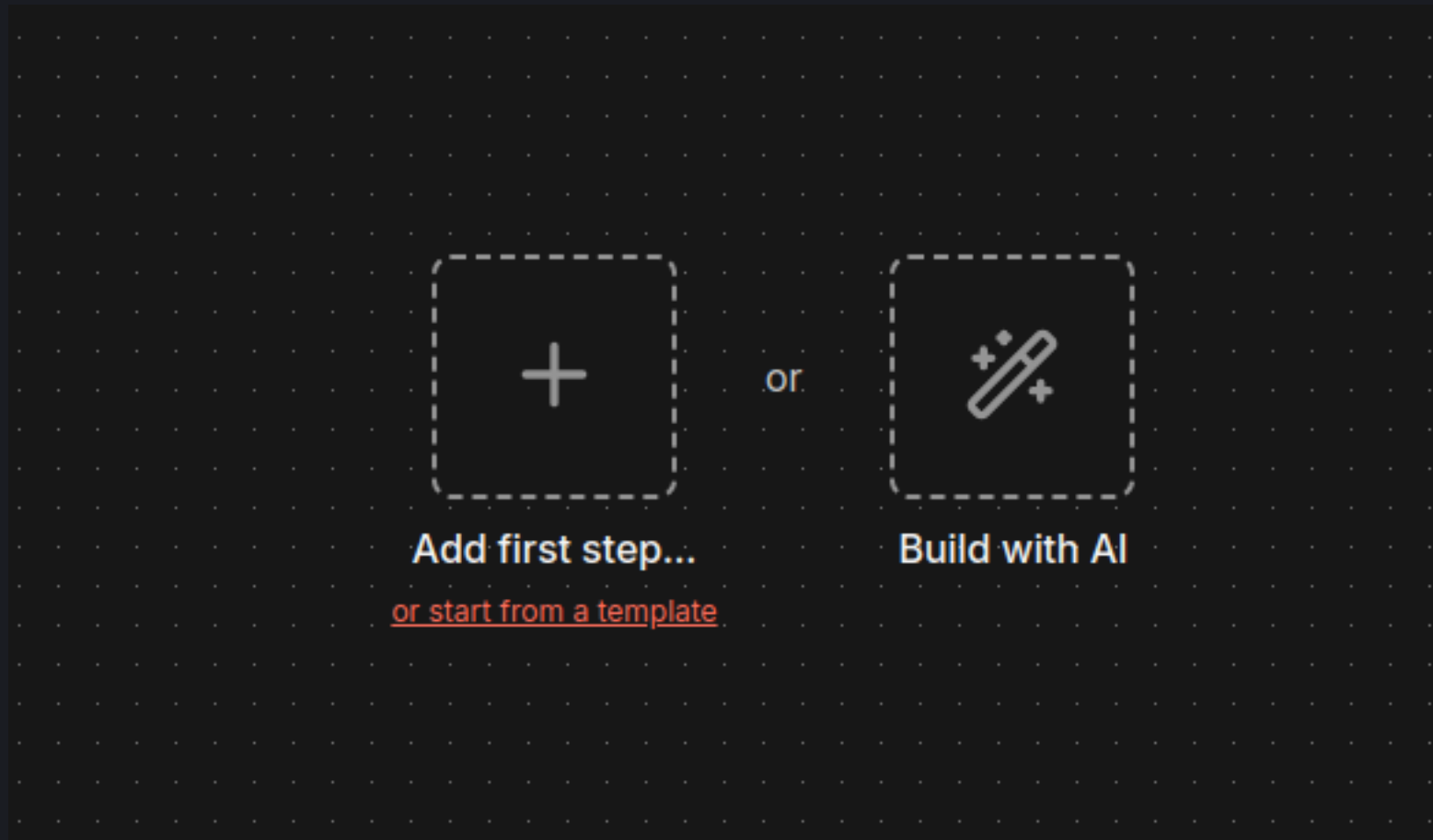
What We're Building

- > 1. Form Trigger → 2. Google Sheets → 3. Switch
- > 4. Gmail → 5. Duplicate Gmail → 6. Merge → 7. Test
- > Form submission → data saved → the right email sent, automatically

Step 1a

Start the Workflow

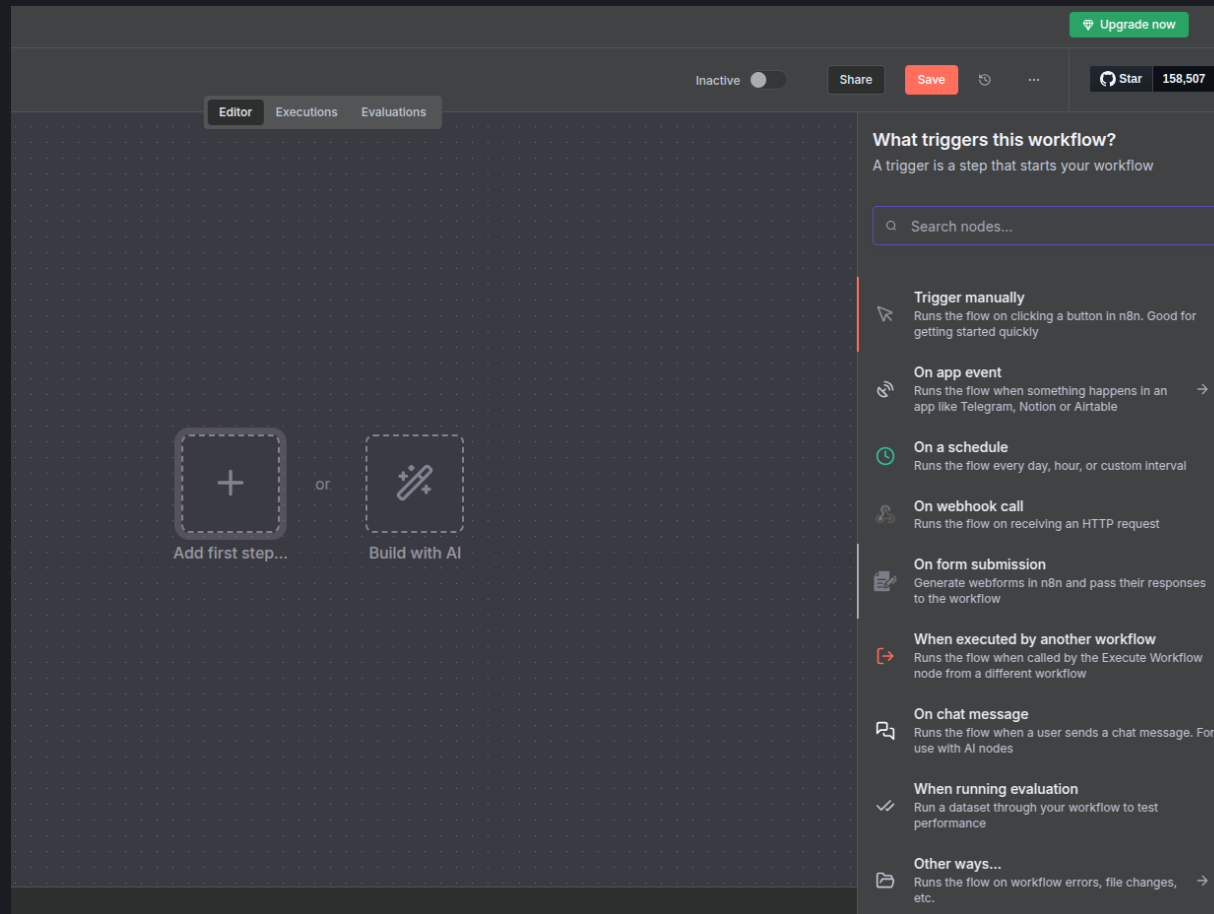
Click “Start from Scratch”, then “Add First Step” to open the node search panel and begin the flow.



Step 1b

Add the Form Trigger

Search “On Submission of Form” in the panel and select it as the trigger for this workflow.



Step 1c

Define the Form Fields

Add the fields to collect from the user, for example Full Name, Industry, Qualification, and Job Title.

The screenshot shows the n8n workflow editor. The main canvas on the left displays a node titled "Pull in a test form submission" with an "Execute step" button. Below it, a message reads: "Activate this workflow to have it also run automatically for new form submissions created via the Production URL. [More info](#)". At the bottom of the canvas, a dropdown menu asks "When will this node trigger my flow?".

The right sidebar is open to the "On form submission" step configuration. It includes tabs for "Parameters", "Settings", and "Docs". The "Parameters" tab is active, showing a "Production URL" field with the value: `https://lucl.app.n8n.cloud/form-test/3a3d5f3d-500f-4379-a091-656c395494e1`. Below this, the "Authentication" is set to "None". The "Form Title" is "Job Form" and the "Form Description" is "This is for testing purpose".

The "Form Elements" section contains two field configurations:

- Field Name:** FullName
- Element Type:** Text
- Placeholder:** name
- Required Field:** (toggle is off)

Below a dashed line, there is another field configuration:

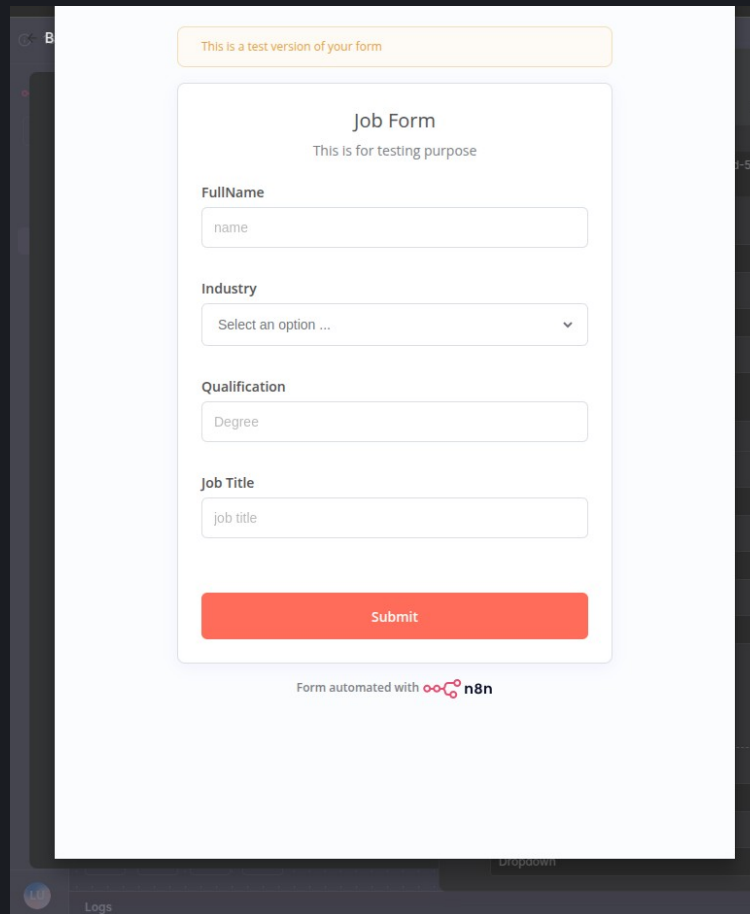
- Field Name:** Industry
- Element Type:** Dropdown

The bottom of the sidebar shows a "Logs" section.

Step 1d

Run It, See the Form

Executing this step generates a live, working form based on the fields you just defined.

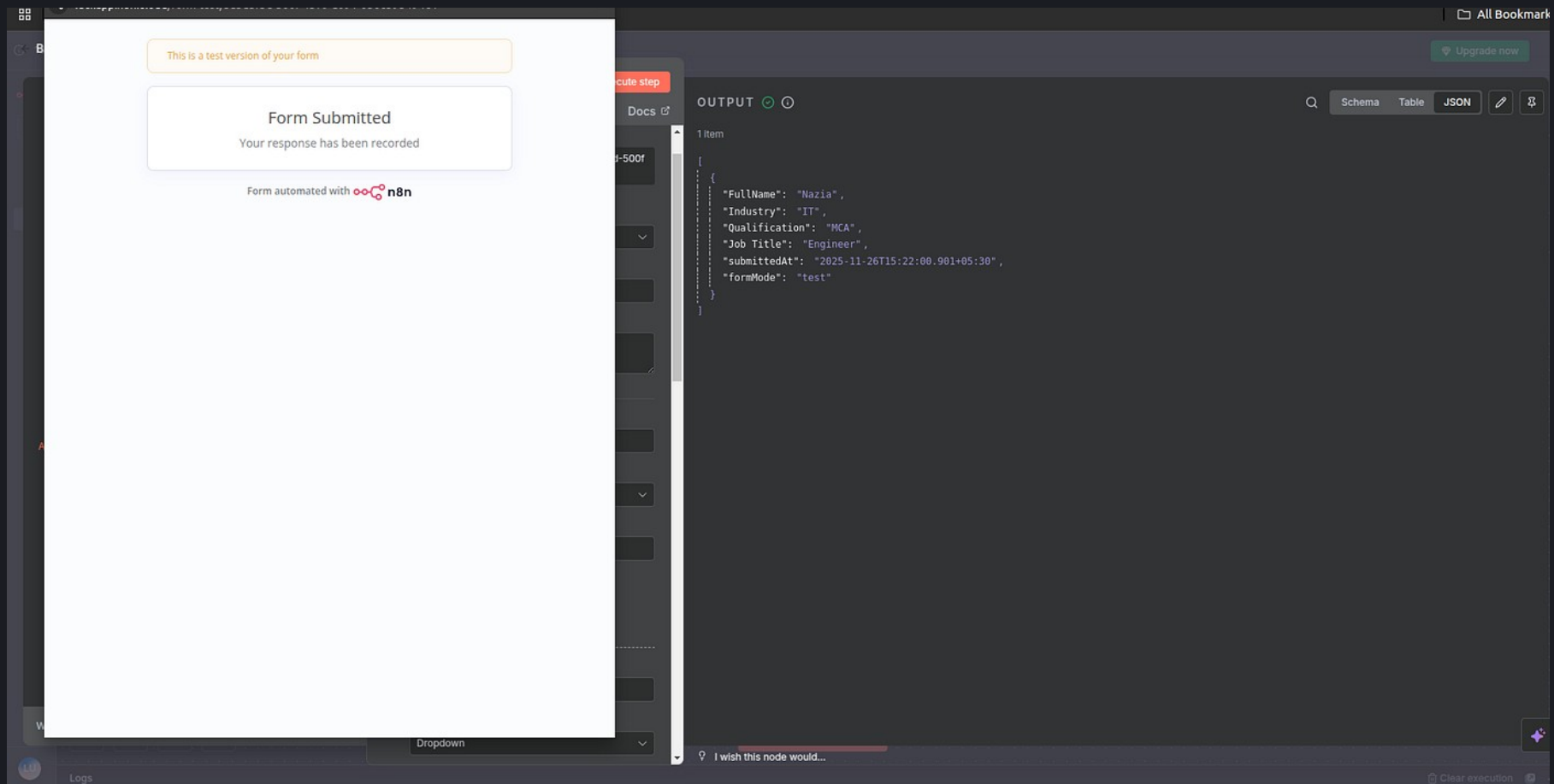


The screenshot shows a web browser displaying a live form titled "Job Form". At the top of the form, a yellow banner reads "This is a test version of your form". Below this, the form title "Job Form" is centered, followed by the subtitle "This is for testing purpose". The form contains four input fields: "FullName" with a placeholder "name", "Industry" with a dropdown menu showing "Select an option ...", "Qualification" with a placeholder "Degree", and "Job Title" with a placeholder "job title". A prominent red "Submit" button is located at the bottom of the form fields. At the very bottom of the page, a footer states "Form automated with n8n", accompanied by the n8n logo. The browser's address bar and a "Logs" tab are partially visible at the bottom of the screen.

Step 1e

Inspect the Output

Submitted data appears as JSON in the output panel. Switch to Table or Schema view to explore it differently.



The screenshot displays a form submission interface on the left and an output panel on the right. The form interface shows a confirmation message: "Form Submitted" with the text "Your response has been recorded" and "Form automated with n8n". The output panel, titled "OUTPUT", shows a single JSON item:

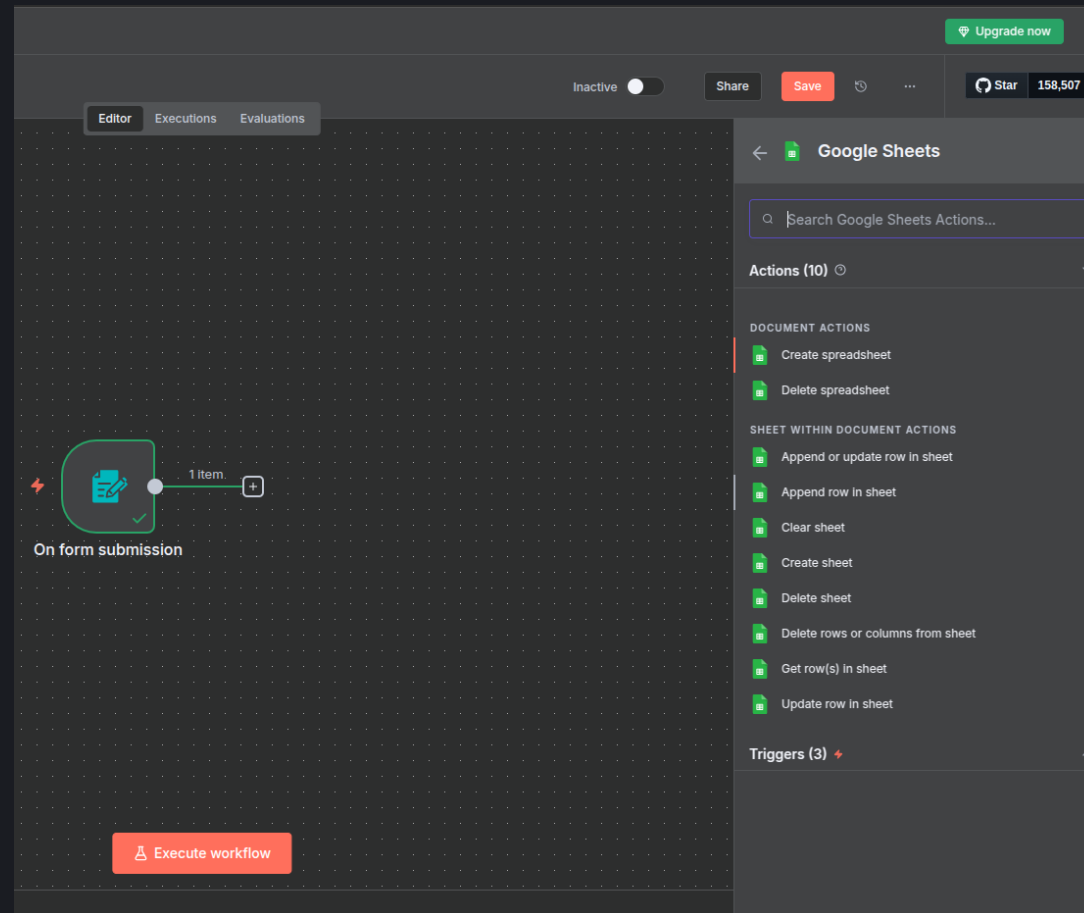
```
{  "FullName": "Nazia",  "Industry": "IT",  "Qualification": "MCA",  "Job Title": "Engineer",  "submittedAt": "2025-11-26T15:22:00.901+05:30",  "formMode": "test"}
```

The output panel also includes tabs for "Schema", "Table", and "JSON", and a "Clear execution" button at the bottom right.

Step 2a

Add a Google Sheets Node

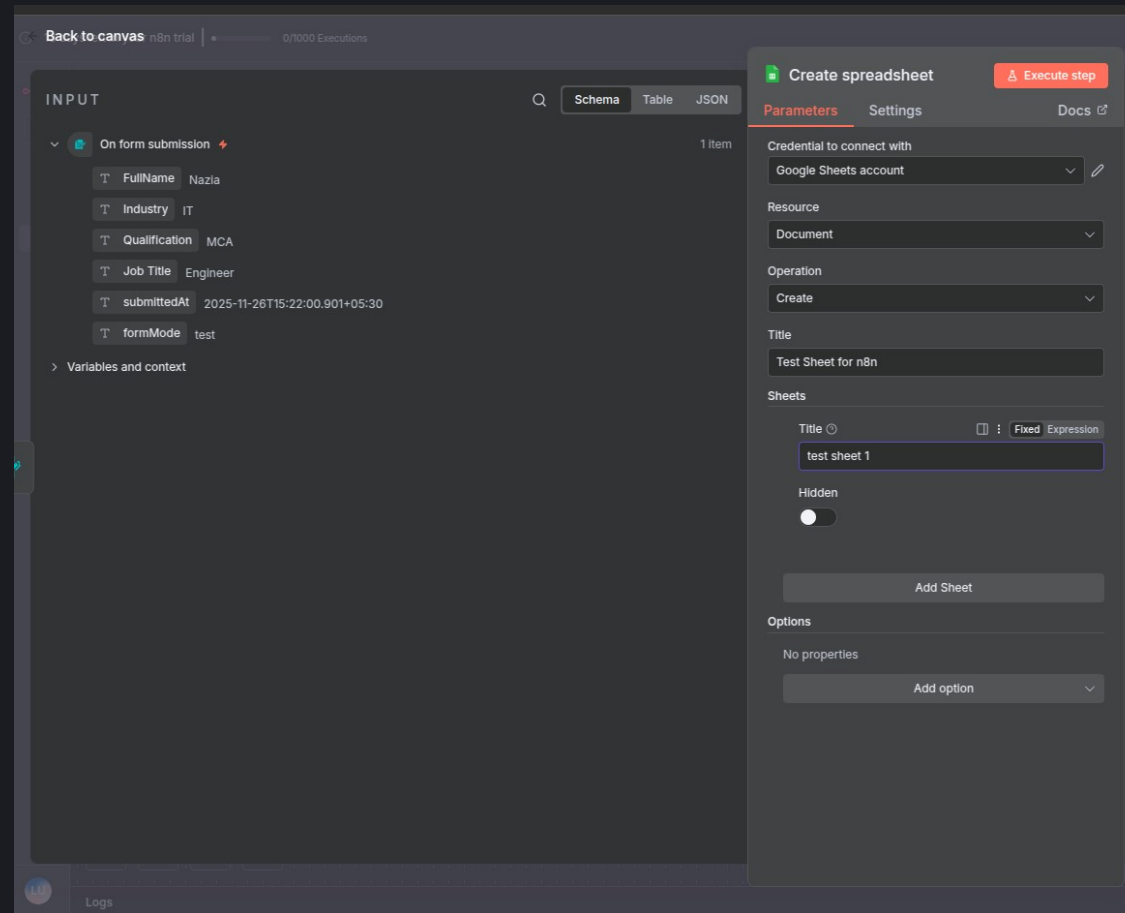
Search “Google Sheets” and choose the “Append Row” action, so every submission becomes a new row.



Step 2b

Point It at a Sheet

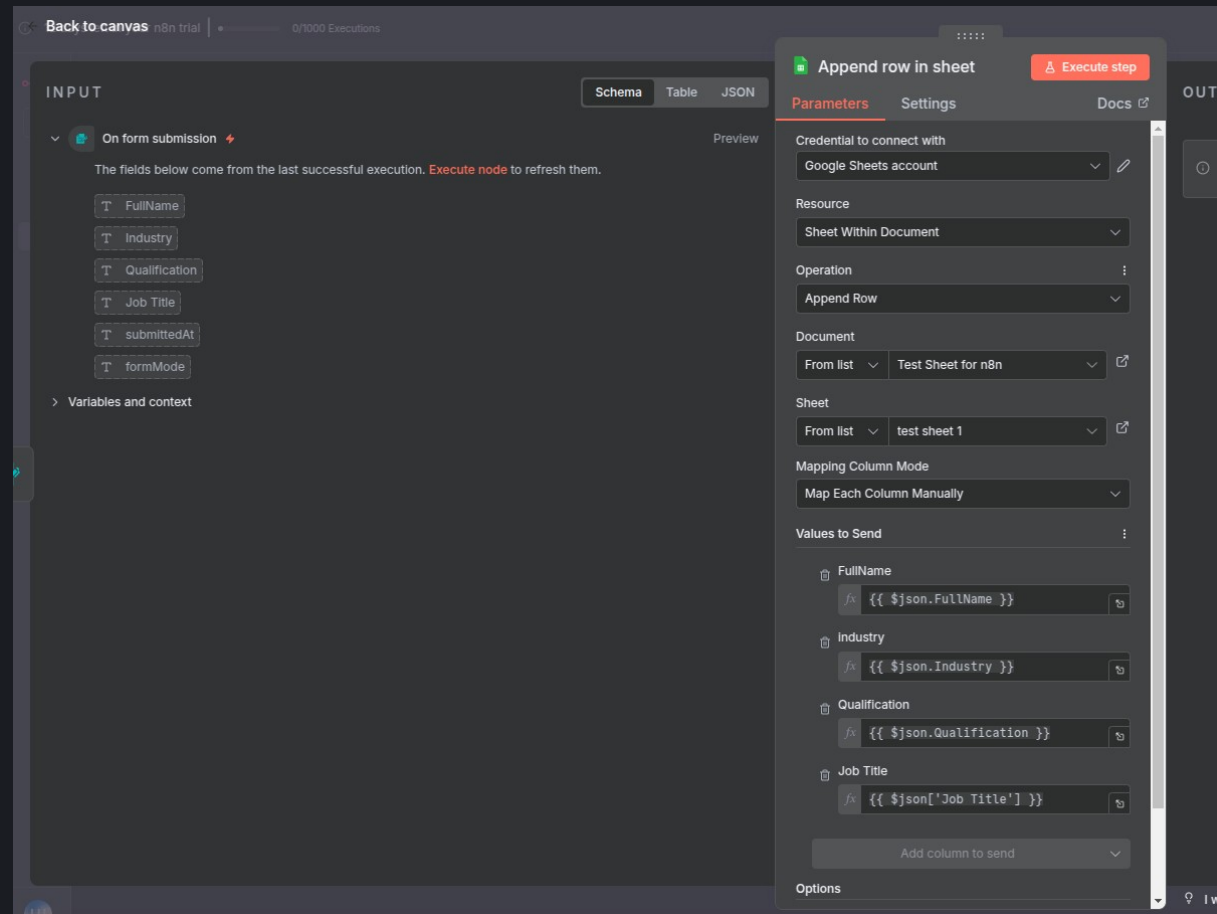
Set Resource to Document, pick the target spreadsheet, and connect your Google account under Credentials.



Step 2c

Map the Columns

Set Resource to Sheet, then drag each form field onto its matching column before executing.



Step 3

Add a Switch Node

Add a Switch node and set routing rules so the flow branches based on a field value, like the selected option.

The screenshot displays the n8n workflow editor. On the left, the 'INPUT' section shows a workflow starting with 'Append row in sheet', which outputs fields: Industry, FullName, Qualification, and Job Title. This is followed by a trigger 'On form submission' and a section for 'Variables and context'. The main canvas shows a 'Switch' node configuration panel on the right. The 'Parameters' tab is active, showing the 'Mode' set to 'Rules'. Under 'Routing Rules', two rules are defined: the first rule uses the expression '{{ \$json.industry }}' and is set to 'Is equal to' 'IT'; the second rule also uses '{{ \$json.industry }}' and is set to 'Is equal to' 'Non IT'. Both rules have 'Rename Output' toggled off. At the bottom of the panel, there are buttons for 'Add Routing Rule' and 'Add option'. The 'Options' section at the very bottom shows 'No properties' and an 'Add option' button.

Step 4a

Add Gmail, Connect the Account

Search “Gmail”, choose “Send Message”, and authorize it via the pencil icon under Credentials.

The screenshot displays the Google App Maker interface. At the top, there are tabs for 'Editor', 'Executions', and 'Evaluations'. The 'Editor' tab is active, showing a workflow diagram on a grid background. The workflow consists of three steps: 'On form submission' (triggered by a lightning bolt icon), 'Append row in sheet' (with a Google Sheets icon and the text 'append: sheet'), and 'Switch' (with a switch icon and the text 'mode: Rules'). A callout box above the first step says 'Waiting for you to submit the form'. Below the workflow, there is a red button labeled 'Waiting for trigger event' and a small square icon. At the bottom of the editor, a message reads: 'Nothing to display yet. Execute the workflow to see execution logs.'

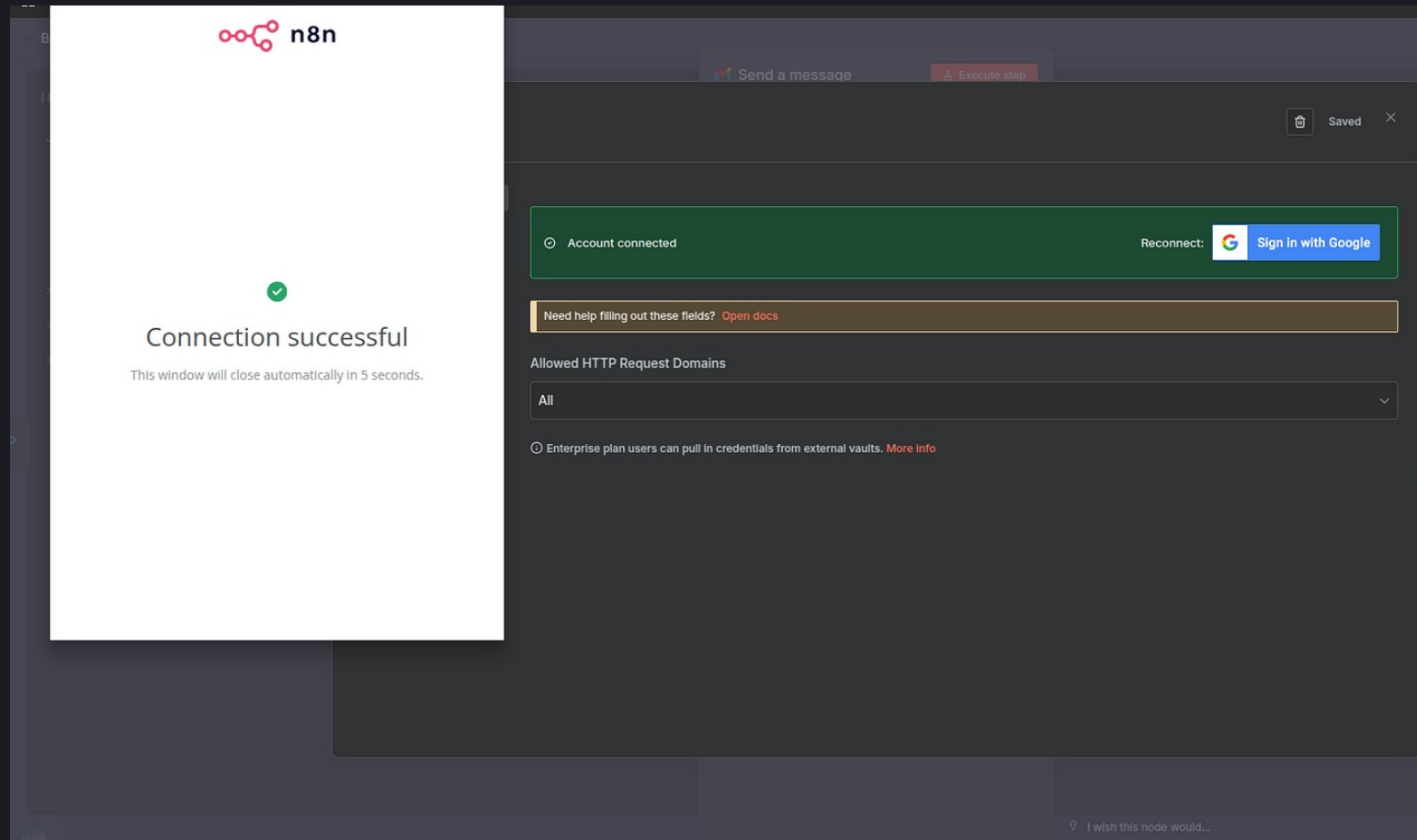
On the right side, there is a sidebar for 'Gmail' with a search bar labeled 'Search Gmail Actions...'. Below the search bar, it says 'Actions (26)'. The actions are categorized into three groups:

- MESSAGE ACTIONS**
 - Add label to message
 - Delete a message
 - Get a message
 - Get many messages
 - Mark a message as read
 - Mark a message as unread
 - Remove label from message
 - Reply to a message
 - Send a message
 - Send message and wait for response
- LABEL ACTIONS**
 - Create a label
 - Delete a label
 - Get a label info
 - Get many labels
- DRAFT ACTIONS**
 - Create a draft

Step 4b

Write the Message

Set Resource to Message, enter the recipient's address, and write the email content to send.



Step 4c

Send It

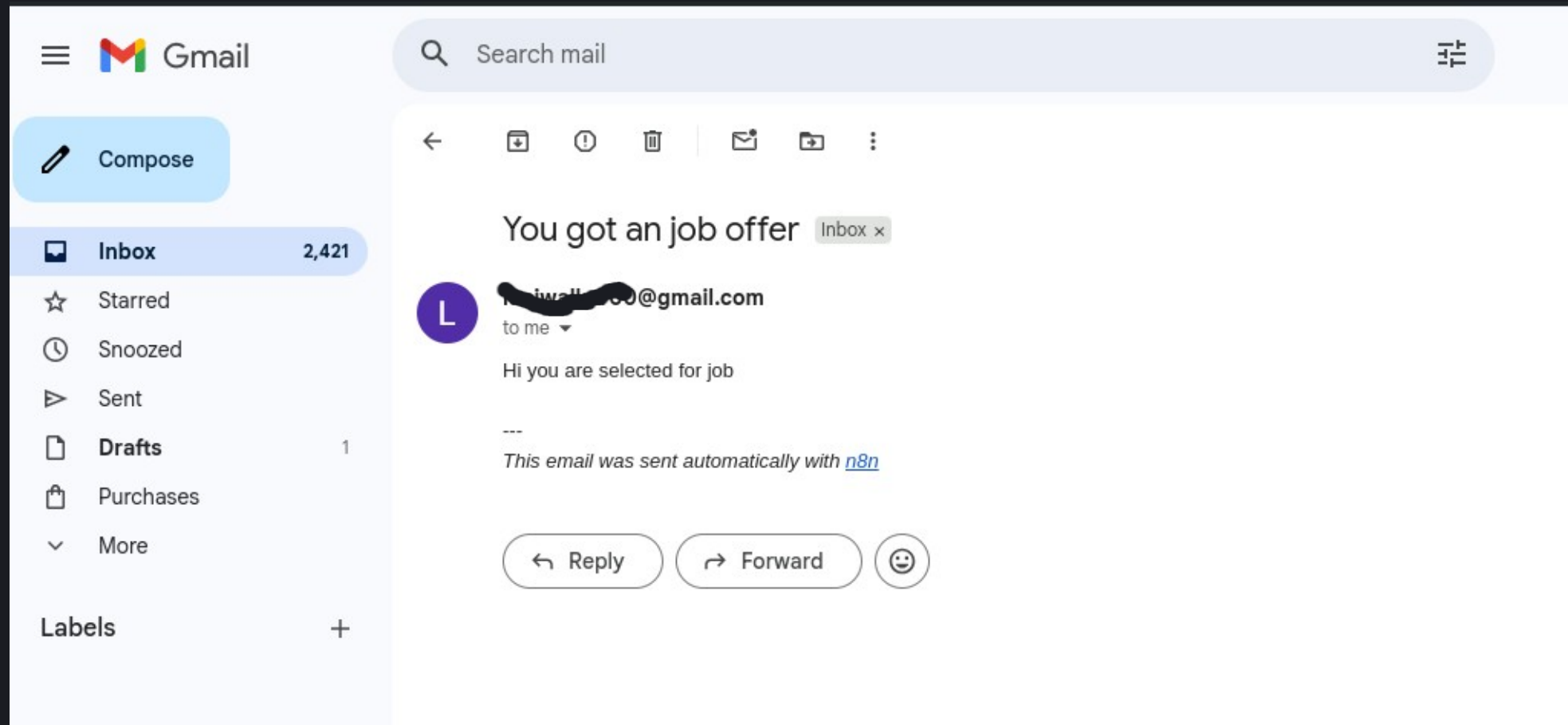
Execute the node and check the inbox. The email sent through the automation should be waiting there.

The screenshot displays the n8n workflow editor interface. On the left, the 'INPUT' section shows a 'Switch' node with four branches: 'Industry' (IT), 'FullName' (Nazia), 'Qualification' (MCA), and 'Job Title' (Python). Below this are 'Append row in sheet', 'On form submission', and 'Variables and context' nodes. The main workspace shows the 'Send a message' node configuration panel. The 'Parameters' tab is active, showing fields for 'Credential to connect with' (Gmail account), 'Resource' (Message), 'Operation' (Send), 'To' (luciwalker00@gmail.com), 'Subject' (You got an job offer), 'Email Type' (HTML), 'Message' (Hi you are selected for job), and 'Options' (No properties). An 'Execute step' button is visible in the top right of the configuration panel. The 'OUTPUT' section is empty. A hint at the bottom right says 'Execute this node to vi or set mock dat'.

Step 4d

Configure the Second Branch

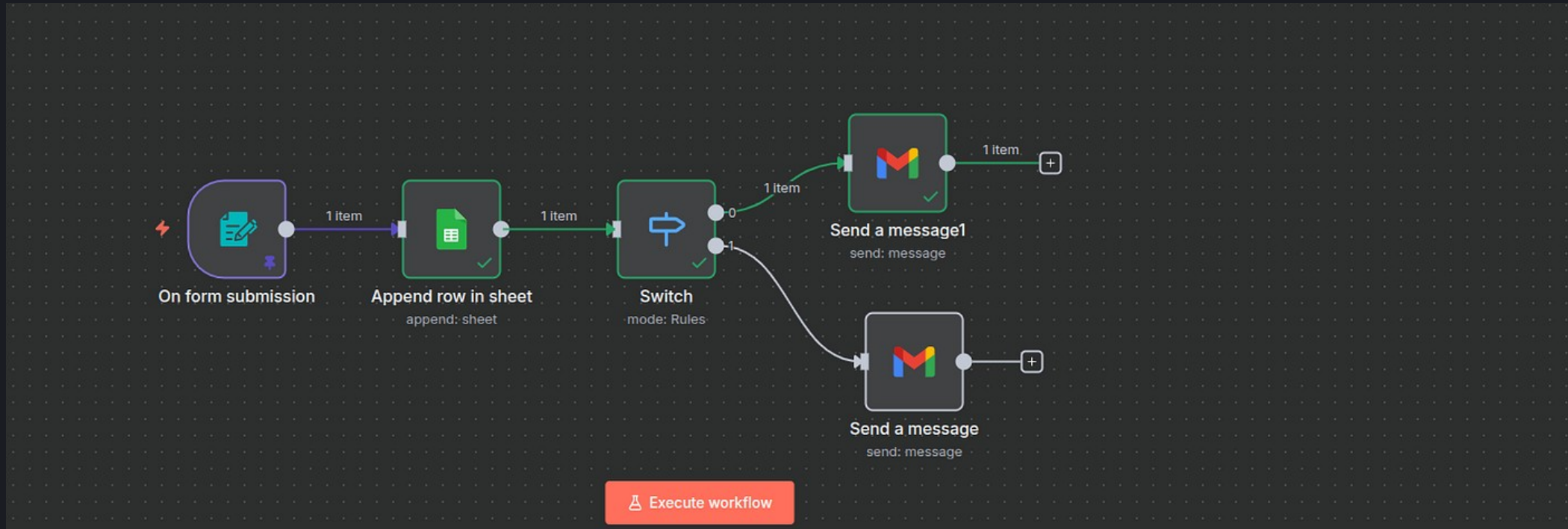
Return to the other Gmail node the Switch can route to, and fill in its message details as well.



Step 5

Duplicate for a Second Response

Right-click the Gmail node, choose Duplicate, and change the message text to reflect the other outcome.



Step 6a

Add a Merge Node

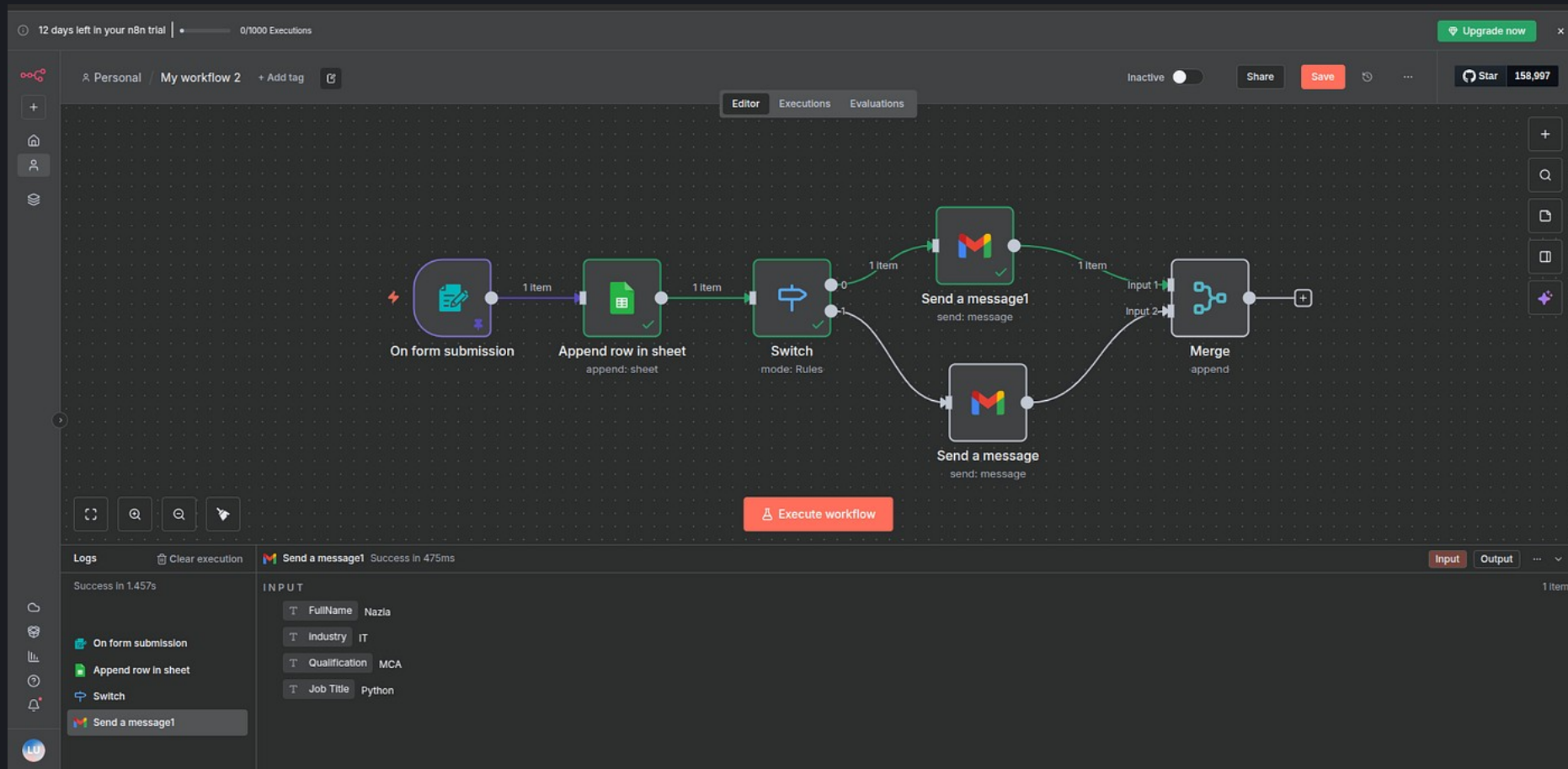
Click the + icon on a Gmail node, search “Merge”, and add it to combine both branches into one path.

The screenshot displays the n8n workflow editor interface. On the left, the 'INPUT' section shows a 'Send a message1' node with a data object containing 'id', 'threadid', and an array of 'labelsids'. Below it are 'Switch', 'Append row in sheet', 'On form submission', and 'Variables and context' nodes. The central panel shows the configuration for a 'Merge' node. The 'Parameters' tab is active, showing 'Mode' set to 'Append' and 'Number of Inputs' set to '2'. An 'Execute step' button is visible at the top right of the configuration panel. The right side of the interface shows the 'OUTPUT' section, which is currently empty, with a message: 'Execute this node to view data or set mock data'. The top of the interface includes a 'Back to canvas' link, a trial status indicator, and an 'Upgrade now' button.

Step 6b

Connect Both Branches

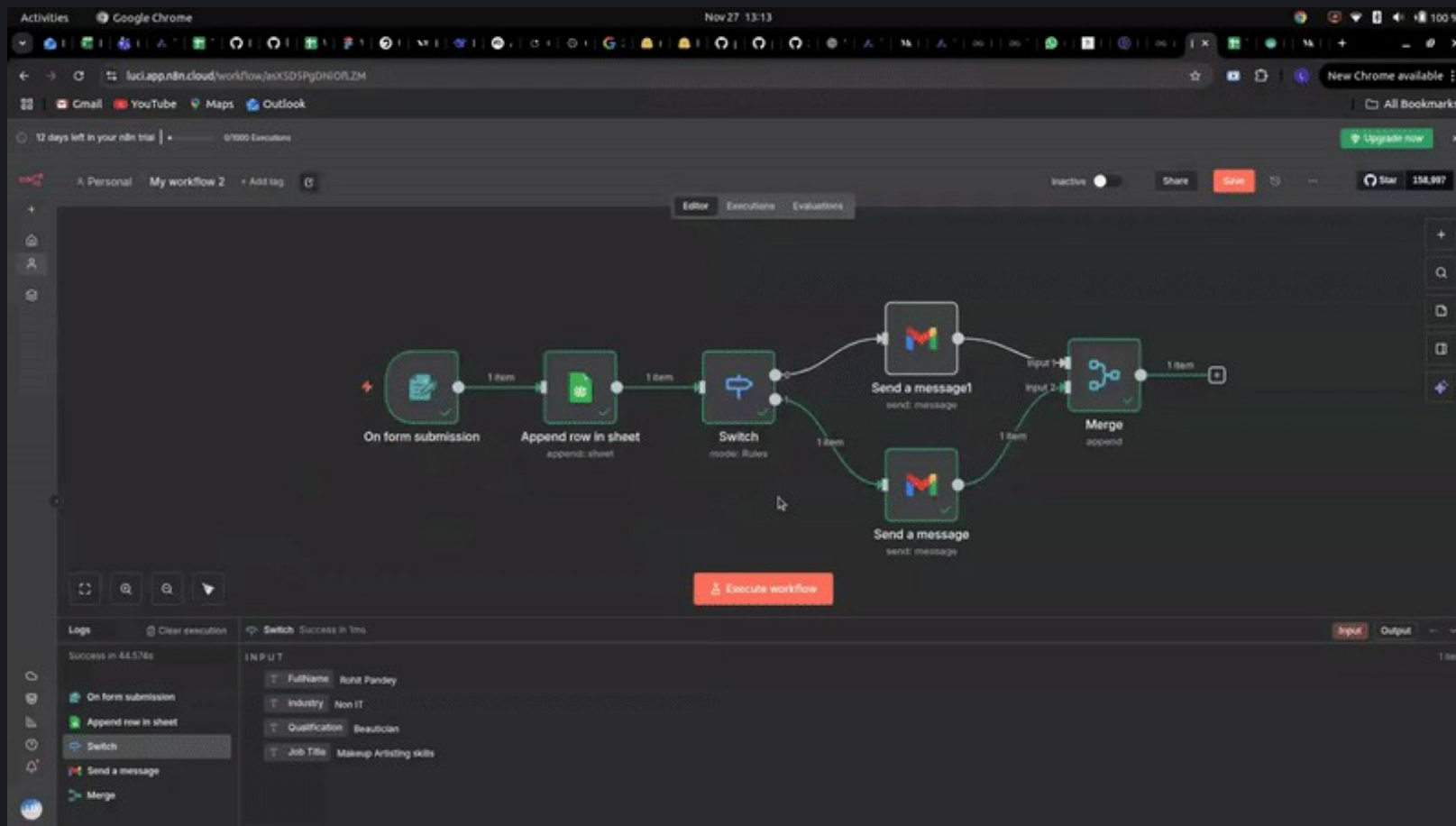
Drag both Gmail outputs into the Merge node. Form submission, sheet update, and the right email are now one flow.



Step 7

Test End to End

Resubmit the form and confirm two things: the row lands in Google Sheets, and the correct email arrives in the inbox.



Conclusion

- › One trigger, seven nodes, zero code: a complete, working automation
- › The same pattern (trigger, act, branch, notify) fits almost any repetitive task
- › Next: try automating something from your own daily work

Source

n8n Tutorial for Beginners: Build Your First No-Code Automation Workflow Step by Step

by Rizwanhoda, published on Towards AI (Medium)

pub.towardsai.net